

would remove one straw of hay until only the needle was left... would that be “intelligent”?

Brute forcing things is pretty much the way of current AI. If it's not that, it's hard-coded responses. If you've ever worked in front office or hospitality, or customer facing roles, you will be familiar with the concept of standard verbiage. This is basically things that you have to say, and tell people in certain situation. It's the reverse of AI, it's trying to turn humans into robots, essentially. If you've called a call center and got frustrated with the non-committal and standard responses, you've been at the receiving end of standard verbiage. Basically, don't think, just respond with Y when customer says X. That's AI in a nutshell today (and everyday before today). I'm pointing at all the smart assistants when I say this!

But...

Yes, I know. They're even coding themselves now aren't they? You've all probably read the hyped up news reports about Google AutoML and Microsoft (and Cambridge University's) DeepCoder supposedly coding themselves. Heck, with AutoML, the headlines screamed about how it was coding better than the programmers who made it! Bah humbug!

Microsoft's DeepCode was using snippets of various code written by humans, and trying to piecemeal them together to see what worked and what didn't. It's like you want to arrive at a given shape, and the bot is programmed to use legos (snippets of code) that some humans built. Now, it's a question of trial and error, and basically brute forcing the problem.

AutoML is similar. The task given to it was to use facial recognition for given images. Now there are points to be marked, then distances and ratios to be computed, and also complex logic that goes over my head, but essentially

what the researchers did was teach it, “Look, we have to get to point X, and you move by doing this, and the set of all possible moves is a trillion trillion, and we've guesstimated our way through and got this path which is 50 percent efficient, can you do better?” (I'm oversimplifying because I'm too dumb to explain it the way the AutoML people did). Now, it's a computer. It can go down every path possible. Is it any surprise it found a more efficient path?

All of this essentially boils down to infinite monkey theorem – get an infinite amount of monkeys who can hit keys on a typewriter, sit them there for an infinity amount of minutes, and eventually one of them will produce Shakespeare's



This chap wants my job!

Hamlet. Does this mean that particular monkey is as intelligent as Shakespeare? Duh! Obviously not!

Human crutches

What is all boils down to is that AI today still needs human crutches – or in other words, they depend so heavily on human input that they're impossible to consider as AI. A prime example is something Robert forwarded to me a month or two ago. It was a Facebook pilot program that was run in Australia, to prevent jilted lovers from sharing naked images of their exes in

anger. Revenge porn it's called, and apparently it's a problem in Australia. You can read more about the experiment here: <http://digit.in/FBXXXRevenge> – and the first thing you will notice is that it requires you (as a victim of revenge porn) to upload naked photographs of yourself to Facebook, which will be looked at by a human who works at Facebook. This is because Facebook's own smart algorithm cannot tell your naked butt from others online. So a Facebook staff member needs to look at your image and create a hash, which will then be used to identify anyone uploading that image. This is, of course, assuming you have all the same images as your ex does of you naked (assuming you sent them to him or her). While it will help someone who does have to face this problem, it's rather telling for us that a human has to be involved in such a thing.

This is why I refuse to call these software codes AI. Not just yet. Sure, maybe they're evolving from bacteria still and will eventually become fish, and then amphibians, and eventually humans and then even surpass us... it's totally possible. But don't start calling them intelligent when they're bacteria! It's sad, the hype is going to cause way too much investment in not so good startups and projects, which will eventually fail (most often, not always), and it will cause another AI bubble to burst. Heck, we've been around long enough to see one happen in our lifetimes already, and I think this is just another case of the enthusiastic marketeers ruining it for the real researchers.

Now I'm going back to playing with my dog. At least when he frustrates me by not listening to my commands, he can wag his tail and flop his ears and look cute, while my stupid Google Home just goes “I'm sorry...” all the time. Stop saying you're sorry. If you keep doing the same damn thing again and again, you're not sorry, you're just dumb! 